# POLITICS AROUND AN ICON'S DEATH

**The emotional call for justice from millions in Assam over Zubeen Garg's death has forced the BJP government to pander to public sentiment. Six months before the state goes to polls, the Opposition has seized on the issue too**

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**"DON'T VOTE FOR US IN 2026 IF WE FAIL TO DELIVER JUSTICE FOR ZUBEEN GARG."** With that one line, delivered barely a week after the death of musician Zubeen Garg on September 19, Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma turned mourning into a political gamble. What began as collective grief over the untimely demise of a wildly popular cultural figure had morphed into protests and conspiracy theories. Sensing the mood, Sarma tied his own fate to a probe that could yet prove to be his undoing. Sarma's critics accuse him of politicising grief; his supporters say he's been forced into damage control by an Opposition doing the same. The truth likely resides in between. Six months before Assam votes, its most adored artiste has become a political fault line.

On that day in September, Zubeen, 52, collapsed while swimming off Singapore's St John's Island. He was visiting as a headliner at the Northeast India Festival. Singapore authorities ruled the death a drowning. A video on social media showed Zubeen joyfully jumping into the sea from a yacht wearing a life vest, only to remove it and re-enter the water minutes before tragedy struck. Yet for millions of Assamese, this explanation felt woefully inadequate. The grief snowballed into an emotional crusade to uncover the truth behind Zubeen's death, coalescing into a social media campaign hashtagged #JusticeforZubeenGarg.

Sarma moved with alacrity. His efforts to court Zubeen's teeming Gen Z following bordered on the theatrical—proclaiming himself among his "top ten fans", personally receiving the body, performing a Zubeen song for the cameras and orchestrating funeral arrangements. This after he had initially dismissed talk of foul play, citing the Singapore authorities' findings.

## THE PUBLIC OUTCRY

The wave of public anger focused on two individuals present in Singapore with Zubeen: Shyamkanu Mahanta, organiser of the Northeast Festival, and Siddhartha Sharma, the artiste's manager. It was speculated that the singer, who had battled seizures for two years and had been medically advised against going into water, might have suffered an episode whilst swimming. The duo ignored this fact, which proved fatal, people alleged.

The emotional catharsis soon acquired political dimensions, largely owing to Shyamkanu's connections. Shyamkanu is the brother of two powerful figures: Assam's information commissioner and former DGP Bhaskar Mahanta, and Nani Gopal Mahanta, vice chancellor of Gauhati University and, until recently, education advisor to the Assam government with cabinet rank. Nani Gopal, a close associate of Sarma, is also close to the RSS and has hosted its chief Mohan Bhagwat twice at his residence. Shyamkanu ran a consultancy firm and organised high-profile events, drawing sponsorships from state and central governments. After Zubeen's death, social media exploded first with photos of Shyamkanu alongside Sarma, followed by images showing him with every major leader in Assam across parties, proof of how deeply embedded he was in the state's power network.

Within a week of Zubeen's death, a conspiracy theory alleged that the singer was silenced after he discovered that Shyamkanu and Siddhartha were exploiting him financially. In the days that followed, over 60 FIRs were filed, accusing the two of offences ranging from criminal negligence to murder.

Sensing the direction of public fury, CM Sarma changed his position. Singapore had conducted an autopsy confirming drowning, a report that was shared by October 1. However, Sarma ordered a second post-mortem at Gauhati